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Designed by
Digital Team

Digital Brand Voice

What is our core value?

We open doors and minds by creating opportunities for learners, employees, employers, and communities, and by shaping the future of college education. Our mission is to include all learners, to challenge our thinking, to remove barriers, and to provide opportunity. We strive to make all learning count. Our core values are respect, inclusion, creativity, teamwork, and resilience.

Bow Valley College's brand voice guideline strives to cultivate a vibrant community at the crossroads of emotion and intellect, fostering genuine connections and sparking curiosity.

Our approachable and intellectually engaging brand voice blends warmth, authenticity, academic prestige, and diversity. Embodying warmth, authenticity, inclusivity, academic excellence, diversity, and a global perspective, Bow Valley College endeavors to foster an intellectually stimulating and emotionally supportive community.

How does voice fit with brand?

We communicate in three ways: the way we look, the way we sound, and the way we behave. Along with our visual identity, our verbal identity is a crucial part of who we are and how we connect with each of our archetypes.

The more consistent we are, the more likely it is that people will understand our value and build trust for our brand.

The *voice* embodies a personality which then sets the *tone* for delivery. Picture getting advised to "watch your tone". There's power in the delivery of words.

A good start is to describe the brand if it was a person, with a bunch of adjectives.
This can serve as the ultimate reference point to test each message against: Does it fit the brand or is it off?

As well as describing who you are, it's also worth describing who you're not.
Who we are: Warm, approachable, authentic, intellectually engaging, and curious, inclusive.
Who we are not: Rude, passive aggressive, compromise on inclusivity or academic rigour.

Example: responding to a complaint:

"*@BVC the PDF is not working for me. Can you help?*"

"*Hey Karl! I'll be glad to help. I'll need some extra details from you to understand what's happening. Could you please DM me so that we can continue there? Thanks!*"

**Do not: "You can find useful information about PDF export here in our help centre: LINK. If you continue to experience issues, open a support ticket: LINK"- very detached and passive.*

Voice Characteristic	Description
Warm & Approachable	It is like a smile or a comforting hug – immediately putting people at ease and inviting them to engage. Simple and confident. We are a voice that fosters connection, trust, and belonging with our audience. Someone you can turn to for support and guidance.
Authentic	It is like a sincere conversation with a trusted friend. Evokes positive feelings. Sincerity, transparency, and consistency; we value honesty and integrity. We speak to our audience in a genuine and relatable manner, fostering trust and building meaningful connections. A brand with authenticity acknowledges its imperfections and takes responsibility for its actions, showing humility and a commitment to continuous improvement.
Intellectually engaging & curious	We are a voice that inspires wonder and encourages exploration, asking our audience to join us in the pursuit of knowledge. Life changing and progressive. We're always looking for new tools and ideas to help create an engaging environment and positive culture. We are committed to critical thinking and the ability to inspire curiosity in our audience. We are a voice that seeks to elevate conversations, challenge assumptions, and provoke thought in a way that is both stimulating and enriching.
Inclusive	We are a voice that celebrates diversity, promotes equity, and fosters a sense of belonging for all. We listen actively, respond with compassion, and demonstrate a commitment to fostering meaningful connections and relationships. We inspire others to be mindful about the impact of our language choices, aim to avoid offense, and strive to use language as a tool to include all populations. Language is in constant flux; both vocabulary and phrases are fluid, changeable, and evolve with time.

Tone of Voice

Elements of Tone

Word length

Short words are simple; this makes your content accessible to all who engage with it. In terms of tone, words are simple and direct, while longer ones suggest sophistication and nuance.

Tempo

You can't just use short words or sentences. To keep readers interested, you've got to mix up length and create a varied rhythm that ebbs and flows. This helps establish an authentic tone for your brand, one that engages the reader.

Pronouns

Use second-person pronouns like "you" to be engaging. When referring about the company, you can either use the first person "we" or third person "Bow Valley College" or "the College".

Sentence length

Using shorter sentences will give you a concise style. The longer your sentences are, the harder they are to understand. An American Press Institute report found:

- For sentences that were 8 words or less, readers understand 100 percent of the information.
- For sentences that were 15 words long, readers understood 90 percent of the information.
- For sentences that were 43 words or longer, comprehension dropped to less than 10 percent.

Conciseness

Using fewer words will allow you to get to the point.This also adheres to the principles of plain language writing, which means your content is accessible to readers of all levels.

Clarity

If conciseness is the ratio of words to ideas, clarity is the degree to which your readers understand your words and ideas.

Contractions

Using them makes your tone informal, relaxed, accessible, and conversational. In turn, this can demonstrate that your brand has a laid-back, yet direct attitude.

Emotionally aware & inclusive

Creating emotionally aware content is when you deliberately choose words to motivate certain reactions from your readers. There's significant research that shows in a world of unlimited choices, emotion helps people to make optimal decisions without being overwhelmed. It also helps convey your brand tone and attitude. Inclusive language demonstrates awareness of the vast diversity of people in the world. Using inclusive language offers respect, safety, and belonging to all people, regardless of their personal characteristics.

Buzzwords/Cliches

Buzzwords are jargon terms that attract people because of their novelty. Some fields, such as the tech industry, generate a lot of buzzwords when naming their innovations. Cliches are words and phrases that have become worn out through overuse. Words like "synergy", "leverage", and "proactive" were once new and fresh but have not become a cliché.

Jargon/Obscure words

Use it judiciously. While good jargon can signal that you're part of a community, bad jargon can alienate and confuse people. You're gambling on whether or not your audience will understand what you mean.

Colloquialisms

The language of every day casual speech. It's a flexible term, because the definition of casual varies from speaker to speaker, and from culture to culture. You can adjust your tone to suit different international audiences. After all, just translating content from it's source language isn't enough if you want to connect with your audience. But be mindful that colloquialisms and slang can be tough for non-English speakers.

Grammar & Rules

Some grammar rules can be bent or broken. For example, starting a sentence with 'and' or 'but', or ending one with a preposition like 'on', may not be strictly correct but more people do it when they talk. So, you might want to do the same if your goal is to achieve a casual mood and conversational tone.

Audiences

Creating a compelling brand voice that adjusts its tone to the specific audience enables direct communication that resonates with their lifestyle and preferences. A well-defined brand tone not only fosters authenticity but also distinguishes you amidst competitors, enhancing engagement.

The effectiveness of conveying your message relies on how well it connects with the reader. The tone employed in writing significantly influences the reader's interpretation of the content. In every context, the brand might sound a bit different: more suit-and-tie on LinkedIn, more relaxed and fun on Instagram, etc. Adapting to the culture and expectations of the audience and the brand-reader relationship.

In the marketing world, companies invest significant effort into crafting the *archetype* of their customer, essentially pinpointing the characteristics of their typical audience. This gains deeper insights into customer motivations, understanding why they choose one business over another, and discovering the factors that influence their purchasing decisions.

Armed with this knowledge, we can optimize advertising strategies and tailor campaigns to the appropriate demographic and enhance overall marketing effectiveness.

EDI Inclusive Language

Equity, diversity & inclusion (EDI) is a strategic initiative at Bow Valley College. To support this important initiative, the EDI working group was formed. The EDI working group was tasked with creating and exploring recommendations for the College around inclusive communication that promotes a sense of belonging and trust.

This complements the EDI Guiding Principles document developed by the EDI working group. It is intended to inspire Bow Valley College employees to be mindful about the impact of our language choices, aim to avoid offense, and strive to use language as a tool to include all populations. Please note that the following are only a few examples of an immense universe of inclusive language alternatives. Language is in constant flux; both vocabulary and phrases are fluid, changeable and evolve with time.

The EDI Working Group has consulted with members of diverse and traditionally excluded groups to ask for their voluntary participation and feedback on the contents of this document. We welcome suggestions and feedback from the College community. Please reach out to the EDI Working Group with comments or suggestions at communications@bowvalleycollege.ca.

You have to question what was once acceptable and determine if it is exclusionary, change your overall mindset about language, then stick around for the evolving conversation.

But first, what is inclusive language?

According to HubSpot, “Inclusive language avoids biases, slang, or expressions that discriminate against groups of people based on race, gender, or socioeconomic status. Inclusive language allows you to resonate with more audiences by speaking and writing in more impartial ways.”

It is our job to make sure that what we write or say is impactful and that our words resonate with our audience. But resonance is about more than relating to the majority. We also need to ensure we don’t alienate or hurt a particular group of people. We have a responsibility to be inclusive and to understand the words we choose – their meaning and origin, and how others might interpret them. Inclusive language is about more than replacing specific words with more acceptable terms; it’s about changing long-held attitudes and habits we don’t think twice about but that the youngest of children, who are just learning to speak and read, hear over and over.

***Language doesn’t have to be offensive to be exclusionary. It is important to consider not just what language might be deemed derogatory or offensive, but also exclusionary. Certain jargon, acronyms, and even emojis that may seem straightforward to you could be unfamiliar or confusing to others, preventing them from participating. Strive to look at your language critically, asking if there are certain words or phrases that might exclude those from outside of your organization, industry, or peer group.*

Gender Identities, Expressions, and Sexualities

When you are addressing a group of people in written communications assume that there is diversity in gender, gender identity, gender expression and sexual orientation. Avoid language that implies a binary in gender or a heterosexual relationship and instead use inclusive language that encompasses everyone.

Before listing a pronoun or gender of an employee or student be sure to ask what their pronouns are and permission to use those pronouns. Simply asking someone their pronouns before putting them in print can easily avoid offending someone and embarrassing yourself. Many words that refer to people's gender identity, expressions or sexualities are more appropriately used as adjectives rather than nouns or verbs. For example, transgender is an adjective, not a noun or verb. With permission, use transgender as a descriptor. Bow Valley College has adopted 2SLGBTQIA+ as the acronym of choice. This stands for Two-spirited, Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, Queer, Intersex, Asexual, and plus.

Not Inclusive	Inclusive Language Alternatives
ladies, gentleman, men, women, boys, girls, guys	students, learners, employees, faculty, staff, guests, folks
Mrs., Mr., Miss., Ms.	use the title that the individual uses where possible. If the person does not utilize a title, do not add one.
man, woman	person
he, she	they
mother, father	parent, loved one, family member, caregiver
husband, wife	spouse, partner, loved one
chairman, chairwoman	chair
spokesman, spokeswoman, businessman, policeman	spokesperson, businessperson, police officer
freshman	first year students
Jane Smith, a transgender, spoke at BVC	Jane Smith, a transgender activist, spoke at Bow Valley College
we support the gays and lesbians in our class	we support the gay and lesbian community in our class
the keynote speaker is a bisexual	the keynote speaker identifies as bisexual
transexual, homosexual, hermaphrodite	these terms are outdated and offensive



Did you know?You can use the "Find and Replace" function in Microsoft Suite (Word, Outlook, Excel, PowerPoint) to quickly replace words across the document you are working on.

Disability

There are two common conventions used when discussing disability and people with disabilities. Person-first language (PFL) uses the sentence structure: “person with a disability.” PFL emphasizes the individual over their condition, highlighting their humanity before their diagnosis or disability.

This language structure is intended to put the focus on the individual and not over-emphasize a diagnosis or disability. It is a way to destigmatize disability, emphasizing that everyone is a person first. PFL is generally used when talking about “people with disabilities” (as a community or group of people), or when discussing specific medical diagnoses as in “student with a broken arm,” “student with ADHD.” Identity-first language (IFL) uses the sentence structure: “disabled person” or “I am disabled.” This language structure emphasizes that an individual’s disability is a core part of their identity, just like their ethnicity, religion, and sexuality. IFL advocates argue that the use of “person with…” helps to perpetuate the belief that a disability is something bad or shameful. Instead, by putting disability first, it is no longer something that you “have,” it is something that you “are.” IFL is extremely important to Deaf, blind, and autistic individuals who have created a disability identity and culture.

Whether you use PFL or IFL, it is important to create stories that normalize disability whenever possible. Do not make special mention of a person’s disability, unless it is relevant to your story or message. Also, do not create stories or use language that heroize or demonize disability—focus on the individual and not the disability.

Not Inclusive	Inclusive Language Alternatives
the deaf, Deaf	Deaf (capitalized when describing community), deaf (lower case to refer to audiological status)
hearing impaired	hard of hearing, deaf or heard of hearing (DHH)
speak with someone	(can exclude D/deaf people who use ASL or sign) use have a conversation, chat
speak up	(can exclude D/deaf people who use ASL or sign) use declare, insist, assert or make plain
stop by and see us	(can exclude blind and people with low vision) use join us, meet with us
the disabled, a disabled person, handicapped	person with a disability
handicapped parking, wheelchair buttons, handicapped bathrooms, etc.	accessible parking, accessible bathrooms, etc.
normal, healthy, whole people	people without disabilities, neurotypical (when referring to cognitive ability)

**See style guide for guidelines on certain terminology.*

Mental Health & Addiction

Mental health encompasses our emotional, psychological, and social well-being, influencing how we think, feel, and behave. It includes factors like mood disorders (e.g., depression, anxiety), psychotic disorders (e.g., schizophrenia), and other conditions affecting cognition and behavior.

Addiction refers to the compulsive use of substances or behaviors despite negative consequences, often leading to physical and psychological dependence. Both mental health and addiction require comprehensive support and treatment to promote recovery and overall well-being.

**See style guide for guidelines on certain terminology.*

Older Adults

Each generation can have different values and perspectives. Remember that older adults can also come from very diverse backgrounds with different language and literacy ability. Keep in mind that many older people perceive themselves as being younger than they really are and the aging population is healthier and more active than previous generations.

Effective messages therefore appeal to a life stage or need or interest rather than a specific age group. Age may be a point of entry for certain things. When age is relevant, use specific ages (e.g., opportunity is available to those aged 55+).

Not Inclusive	**Inclusive Language Alternatives**
Young people are better at using technology or old people are worse at using technology	Some people are better/worse at using technology than others
Retiree	People who are retired
• Senior citizens • Seniors (when trying to include people aged 65 or younger) • The aged • The elderly • Oldsters • Mature • Boomer	Don't use a single word or phrase to describe the population of people 45 or 50 years and older. Instead, use: • Adults aged (insert age) and older • People aged (insert age) and older • Ageing adults • Older adults

Religion and Spirituality

Do not assume all persons of a specific race, ethnicity or region observe a particular religion. For instance, different Indigenous nations have their own religious institutions and sacred practices. Do not assume all persons of a specific religion practice the same way as culture has impacts on how religion is observed. Make attempts to speak to a particular sect of a religious group to avoid generalizations. Understanding nuances conveys sensitivity and respect.

Avoid assuming that everybody celebrates the same religious holidays that the dominant group celebrates. Avoid offending non-Christians and non-believers. Do not capitalize atheist or agnostic. Nonreligious has no hyphen. Ensure communication addresses a sensitivity to religious requirements (e.g., wearing of masks by persons with facial hair, hijab, head scarves, turbans).

Not Inclusive	**Inclusive Language Alternatives**
Happy EID	Eid Mubarak
Labelling religious holidays as “their Christmas”	Research and use the most accepted name for each religious holiday
Christmas vacation	Winter vacation
Using specific religious greetings when you don’t know if that person is of that religion	Avoid mention of any specific religion or religious holidays, unless it is relevant and/or necessary

Racialized People

Capitalize the proper names of nationalities, peoples, races and tribes (e.g., Indigenous Peoples, Métis, Cree, Inuit, Arab, Jamaican-Canadian, Jew, Latin, Asian). Avoid singling out specific cultures or drawing undue attention to ethnic or racial background.

When references are relevant and necessary, find the appropriate, accepted terminology and use the language preferred by the individual or group concerned.

BIPOC (Black, Indigenous, People of Color) is an emerging term now used to “highlight the unique relationship to whiteness that Indigenous and Black (African Americans) people have, which shapes the experiences of and relationship to white supremacy for all people of color” (thebipocproject.com, 2020). Be aware that some terms can unintentionally have negative racial connotations. Avoid vocabulary that carries hierarchical valuation or portrays groups as inferior, criminal, or less valued than others.

Not Inclusive	**Inclusive Language Alternatives**
Negro (referring to a person)	Black or self-identified nationality (e.g., Somali-Canadian)
Oriental (referring to a person)	Asian or the person's nationality if appropriate
Brown (referring to a person)	Racialized person or the person's nationality if appropriate
Master/slave (technology terms)	Primary/secondary, leader/follower
Spanish (for people not from Spain), Mexican (referring to all South American people)	Latinx, Latina/Latino, Latin American, demonym (if relevant)
Minority group	Equity-deserving group
Visible minority, person of colour	Racialized group, racialized person, member of a racialized group
Anglicization of personal names (change of non-English-language personal names to spellings nearer English sounds)	Personal names are part of a persons identify. Strive to pronounce and spell personal names following the person's preferred pronunciation and spelling. When in doubt, just ask.

Immigrants and Refugees

Immigrant: Refers to a person who is, or who has ever been, a landed immigrant or permanent resident. Such a person has been granted the right to live in Canada permanently by immigration authorities. Immigrants who have obtained Canadian citizenship by naturalization are included in this group (Statistics Canada, 2019).

Landed Immigrant: Refers to a person who has been granted the right to live in Canada permanently by immigration authorities. (Statistic Canada, 2017).

International Student: International students are defined as "non-Canadian students who do not have 'permanent resident' status and have had to obtain the authorization of the Canadian government to enter Canada with the intention of pursuing an education." (Statistics Canada, 2010).

Permanent resident: Someone who has been given permanent resident status by immigrating to Canada but is not a Canadian citizen (Government of Canada, 2019).

Refugee: A person who has fled their country because of a well-founded fear of persecution. They are not able to return home. They have seen or experienced many horrors (Government of Canada, 2019).

Newcomer: Newcomers to Canada who have established residential ties with Canada may be: protected persons (including refugees) within the meaning of the immigration and Refugee Protection Act., or people who have applied for or received permanent resident status from Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada. The Government of Canada usually characterizes a newcomer as someone who has been in the host country for five years or less (Government of Canada, 2019).

Not Inclusive	**Inclusive Language Alternatives**
Illegal immigrant	Undocumented
Citizens (when referring to general population)	Residents
Third World	Majority world, low-income countries (according to World Bank statistics, 80 percent of humanity lives on $10 or less a day)
First World	Minority world, high-income countries

Income

Many find the terms “low class” and “poor” pejorative. Use person-first language instead. Define income brackets and levels if possible. Avoid language that focuses on blaming the individual or on individual deficits. Instead focus on what participants have (not what they are perceived to lack) and use empowering language by avoiding terms like “struggling.”

When comparing groups, use parallel terminology (e.g., people with a high school diploma vs. without a high school diploma or equivalent, not high-school dropouts vs. high-school graduates).

Not Inclusive	**Inclusive Language Alternatives**
Disadvantaged	People with low incomes
Vulnerable (except for homelessness)	People facing barriers/multiple barriers
Poor/poorest	People with incomes below the poverty line
The homeless	People who are unhoused
Welfare	Income Support
People on benefits	People who receive benefits
High school drop outs, achievement gap	People who have less than high-school education, opportunity gap